

accepted many of the customs of the land of their adoption, but had never become absolutely one with the people of the country. The reason for this continued detachment lay in the religion these people followed. It baffles Westerners that it should be so. . . . Religion did make different people of them, influencing their way of life. . . . Hinduism had hitherto absorbed most other conquerors, but the clear-cut tenets of Islam defied amalgamation with any other creed. . . . The rigid caste system of the Hindus . . . prevented any possibility of free social intercourse . . . [and] there was also the gulf separating the rulers from the ruled. . . . Though in the case of the Muslims and Hindus, the gulf was not as great as between the British and the Indians, it still existed.

When the Muslim rule in India was succeeded by the British, the basic difference between the two peoples did not disappear. If anything, it grew stronger. The Muslims felt themselves threatened both by the supremacy of the British as rulers and by the numerical superiority of the Hindus. . . . They held more tenaciously to their own way of life[,] . . . to every little thing that made their culture different from the Hindus. These differences may seem trivial . . . but to the Muslims they were like sentinels guarding their separate existence in a sea of aliens.

[From Begum Shaista S. Ikramullah, *From Purdah to Parliament* (London: Crescent Press, 1963), 86–88, 89, 99–102, 103, 118–119, 135–136, 137–138, 139–140, 141, 142, 151, 152, 153, 154, 155–157, 158–161.]

URVASHI BUTALIA: SURVIVORS' ORAL ACCOUNTS

The events that led up to Partition, and then the division of the subcontinent as the British exited, affected millions of ordinary people. Most of the documents above describe the views and actions of the elite actors in this immense drama. For the impact of these events on the lives of the many, we have to turn to extracts from an excellent work of oral history by Urvashi Butalia, a director and cofounder of the feminist organization Kali for Women, who spent years gathering these stories on both sides of the border and putting them in vivid shape for her readers.

STORIES OF FLIGHT, ABDUCTION, AND HONOR KILLING

FROM 3. "FACTS"

In 1990 Sudesh and I began to speak to Rajinder Singh, a three-wheeler scooter driver in Delhi. We boarded his scooter, to get from one part of the city to another. Somewhere along the way, because he looked the right age, we asked him where he was from. He suggested that we come to his home and he would tell us his story. The story took us to Gandhi Nagar, a resettlement area on the

outskirts of Delhi where Rajinder Singh and his family lived in a small house set deep in a narrow, crowded lane. As with all the families we visited, they welcomed us into their homes as if we belonged there. The several sessions during which we interviewed him and his brother, Manmohan Singh, were interspersed with long conversations with neighbours . . . who had their own stories to tell. . . . Rajinder or Manmohan asked themselves if they should be telling us this. As always in family situations, we seldom got to speak to the wives. . . . We later decided not to attempt to speak to men and women at the same time, but to do so separately.

Partition meant many different things to different people. For Rajinder Singh, his most powerful memory is not of the event itself but of something that took place a few years earlier when, as a young boy, he ran away from home to join a group of street singers and prostitutes in Hira Mandi in Lahore. Four years after his disappearance, his father managed to track him down and went to the kothah [courtesans' house] to fetch him back. The young Rajinder watched from the roof of the kotha as his father walked through the marketplace, he listened to the jibes and taunts directed at the old man, and then saw him being deliberately tripped by a flower seller at the foot of the stairs of his "home." As he fell, Rajinder's father's turban came loose and rolled off, the ultimate loss of honour for a Sikh. Broken, the old man gathered up his turban and walked slowly away. Torn between his wish to stay on in a place which he loved and his compassion for his father, Rajinder followed him to the railway station, and . . . to his home where he then began a job in a utensil factory. . . .

It was there that he first came across evidence of the divisions that became much more visible after Partition. The factory owner, a Hindu, employed Sikhs, Hindus and Muslims and, as Partition drew closer, fights began to break out between them. Rajinder has no special feelings of enmity or hatred towards his Muslim co-workers. . . . Like many people who did not have a "profession," Rajinder turned his hand to different things after he crossed over to India: he worked in a halvai [sweet] shop in Amritsar, later set up his own halvai shop, drove a tonga for a while, and when we met him, was driving a scooter which he owned. I have chosen to include a section of Rajinder's interview here because he describes how people from his family and his village came away on foot, in a kafila [caravan] that grew as more and more people joined it. Up to a certain distance the kafila was accompanied, and presumably protected, by the Pakistani army, and then the Indian army took over. He said he had never really told this story to anyone before. . . . Yet, as we sat and spoke, family members came in again and again and asked us to replay this or that incident, as if listening to his voice on tape somehow invested it with a greater authority. . . . I find Rajinder's account moving, for its sense of inexorable, slow, tortuous movement as people headed . . . from a life shattered by forces beyond their control, into an unknown future. In his words, "Our hearts were full of fear—where were we

headed? Where would we end up?”—a question that runs through virtually every Partition narrative . . .

Rajinder Singh:

“My bua’s [older sister’s] older son’s in-laws lived in a village called Richade. My brother went there with my bua’s younger son. He thought, we have to go out this way anyway, so let’s go little by little so that everyone does not get killed all at once. We sort of knew we would have to die anyway, so we thought that if we spread ourselves out then we could perhaps see if one or the other could be saved. I went to fetch my wife . . . but I was worried that my brother would get left behind. So we all came to a place called Baba Lakhan, we came there and people from that village stopped there. I said to them, there are so few of you, why don’t you also include people from this village. There are many Sikhs, include them and our kafila will grow large and become strong. As it is there are only a few people from this one village, why not increase the size of the kafila? In this way we kept progressing and others joining up and the kafila kept growing. We went to another village and found that everyone there was sleeping comfortably . . . When we went and told them, they said, no, can these sorts of things ever happen? I said to them if they have not happened before, they have happened today. If you think these kinds of things will not happen, you are mistaken, they are happening. So some of the older people started to pay attention. They asked, are you speaking the truth? I said, yes, go outside and look, go to Baba Lakhan. There are many people there, waiting . . . When we came back to Baba Lakhan we found people from two more villages had collected there. Now there were some thousand people or so . . . earlier there had only been four or five hundred . . . Hindus, Sikhs . . . Whatever people could pick up, big things and small, they put clothes on top of those they were wearing, and threw a khes or sheet over their shoulders. They picked up whatever they could and then they joined the kafila. Who could take along heavy things? And the kafila began to move. The next village on the way was Katiana. There, there was a marriage, a Musalmaan’s wedding, and there were a lot of fireworks and things going on. We thought there was firing and guns, so we stopped the kafila some distance away from the village. Some people said they would go and find out . . . as they were leaving people said to them, you should be careful, don’t go openly. It shouldn’t happen that you have gone to find out and you just get killed yourself . . . they went . . . and they heard music and realized it was a wedding!

“Gradually, daylight came. This was the first night, and then it became morning and as the sun rose, it began to rain. It rained so much and our clothes became so heavy . . . we could not even lift them. Our clothes got more and more wet, and people just left them there. Our stomachs were empty, we were hungry, our clothes were wet and sodden, our hearts were full of fear—where were we headed? Where would we end up? Our hearts were full of grief: what

will happen? Where will we go? It's like when you started from home today, you knew you were going to Gandhi Nagar. We did not even know this. Which nagar [city], which side, which direction . . . we had no desire to eat, nor was there anything to eat. After all, when we left our homes, we did not carry our atta [grain] with us, we did not take the rotis from our tavas [metal griddles]. We did not think that we will take atta and knead it and cook it. We just left, as we were, empty-handed. Then some people fell ill—some fell ill from grief, some got diarrhoea, some had fever . . . so many people had left all of a sudden, they could not all be healthy and stay well. Some were ill from before, some fell ill from sorrow, and then there was rain and then the sun. The heat and cold made people's bodies shrivel up . . . from . . . these changes people fell ill . . . it was afternoon in Batiana before we knew it.

"There was one woman who was pregnant and about to give birth. The whole kafila began moving, but she was already a little upset and she said, you people go on ahead, I am prepared to die. In any case, I have no one to call my own. The hardship I have to face, I will bear, don't worry about me . . . the baba who was with me, I said to him, baba, it is given to some people to do good. Your granddaughter was with you and you decided to come with me. I kept telling you why bother . . . but look at this poor woman, she is about to give birth, she is a young woman, and here she is lying in the road . . . let us try to do good. We are all full of grief, we are all weeping. He said, what is it? I said, look at that girl, she has no brother or father, and she is alone, her man has been killed and she is about to give birth. There were some other women sitting with her, and when the kafila began to move, they too started to move. So my baba said, girl sit on my horse, and wherever we find someone who can help, we will take you there. But perhaps from fear, she gave birth right there, to a daughter. Out of fear. No one had a knife or anything, you know the instruments you need to cut the cord. There was one man, and he had a kind of sword, we asked him, baba, this is the thing, please help us. So he gave it to us and the women cut the cord, and we stopped the kafila for about three quarters of an hour. We said to them, you are leaving your honour behind to go to the houses of unknown people. Even if you get a little late, how does it matter? On the way there was a village called Pasroor. We had the Baluchi military with us. They put us in a school there. They said, anyone who tries to get out of here, out of these four walls, we will cut him down. The school had a four-foot-high wall. They tried to be strict but we had nothing to eat or drink . . . so people went, they broke into a shop and they brought some sacks of mungphalis [peanuts], so we roasted those and ate them. After all, what else could we do? Someone got this much and someone got that much. Then someone else jumped the wall and got to the sugarcane fields nearby to steal sugarcane. The military people killed some of them—in front of us they killed a Jat. His family had a cart, they had loaded things on to it and brought it, so they set fire to it and used it for the last rites of their man who was killed . . .

“After Narowar, the Madras military joined the *kafila* . . . they told the Baluchis to go away, that their duty had finished and they should go away. . . . The two militaries confronted each other. One said, it is our duty, while the other said, your duty is over, you should go away . . . the wells had medicine and poison in them, there were dead people in there, there was no water to drink, we were hungry and thirsty . . . nothing to eat, nothing to drink. Then our military brought two trucks to Narowar and they were filled with *atta*. They spread a tarpaulin and handed out *atta* to people, saying take as much as you want. They gave us corn, they kept giving it to us saying eat, destroy their fields. The Madras military really helped us. Everyone was grief stricken. Someone’s mother had died, someone’s father had gone, someone’s daughter had been abducted . . . then we moved on. You know you feel some fear of a dead body, but at the time, we had no fear at all. . . . From there we came to the bridge on the Ravi. There they told us, this is the limit of our duty, we are now going back to help the *kafila* that has come from Daska. We saw a trainload of Hindus had been killed and in Dera Baba Nanak, a trainload of Musalmaans who had come from the direction of Ludhiana had been killed . . . they killed each other’s people. We saw bodies of Musalmaans, utensils lying in the mud, clothes[,] . . . some people buried under others, and disease and illness all around. When we got to Dera Baba Nanak they said to us, you have come home. But we thought, our home was over there. We have left it behind. How can this be home?”

[From Urvashi Butalia, *The Other Side of Silence*
(Durham: Duke University Press, 2000), 78–83.]

FROM 5. “HONOUR”

“My name is Basant Kaur. My husband’s name was Sant Raja Singh. We came away from our houses on March 12, and on the 13th we stayed out, in the village. At first, we tried to show our strength, and then we realized that this would not work, so we joined the *morcha* [procession] to go away. We left our home in Thoa Khalsa on the 12th. For three or four days we were trapped inside our houses, we couldn’t get out, though we used to move across the roofs of houses and that way we could get out a bit. One of our people had a gun, we used that, and two or three of their people died. I lost a brother-in-law. He died from a bullet they fired. It hit him and he died. So we kept the gun handy. Then there were fires all around, raging fires, and we were no match for them. I had a *jeth*, my older brother-in-law, he had a son, he kept asking give me *afim* [opium], mix it in water and I will take it. My *jeth* killed his mother, his sister, his wife, his daughter, and his uncle. My daughter was also killed. We went into the *morcha* inside the village, we all left our houses and collected together in the centre of the village, inside the *sardaran di haveli*, where there was also a well. It was Lajjawanti’s house. The *sardar*, her husband, had died some time ago but his wife and other women of the house were there. Some children also. They all came

out. Then we all talked and said we don't want to become Musalmaan, we would rather die. So everyone was given a bit of afim, they were told, you keep this with you . . . I went upstairs, and when I came down there was my husband, my jeth's son, my jethani, her daughters, my jeth, my grandsons, three granddaughters. They were all killed so that they would not fall into the hands of Musalmaans. One girl from our village, she had gone off with the Musalmaans. She was quite beautiful, and everyone got worried that if one has gone, they will take all our girls away . . . so it was then that they decided to kill the girls. My jeth, his name is Harbans Singh, he killed his wife, his daughter, his son . . . he was small, only eight days old. Then my sister-in-law was killed, her son and her daughter, and then on the 14th of March we came to Jhelum. The vehicles came and took us, and we stayed there for about a month and then we came to Delhi.

"In Delhi there were four of my brothers, they read about this—the camp—in the papers and they came and found us. Then, gradually, over a period of time the children grew up and became older and things sorted themselves out. My parents were from Thamali. Hardly anyone survived from there. You know that family of Gurmeet's, they had two sisters, the Musalmaans took them away. It's not clear whether they died or were taken away, but their bodies were never found . . . Someone died this way, someone that, someone died here and someone there, and no one got to know. My parents were burnt alive.

"That whole area was like jungle, it was village area. One of my brothers survived and came away, one sister. They too were helped by a Musalmaan, there were some good ones, and they helped them—he hid them away in his house—and then put them into the vehicles that came, the military ones. The vehicles went to Mator and other places. In Mator, Shah Nawaz made sure no harm came to them. People from Nara managed to get away, but on the way they were all killed. Then my brothers read the papers and got to know. My husband, he killed his daughter, his niece, his sister, and a grandson. He killed them with a kirpan. My jeth's son killed his mother, his wife, his daughter, and a grandson and granddaughter, all with a pistol. And then, my jeth, he doused himself with kerosene and jumped into a fire.

"Many girls were killed. Then Mata Lajjawanti, she had a well near her house, in a sort of garden. Then all of us jumped into that, some hundred . . . eighty-four . . . girls and boys. All of us. Even boys, not only children, but grown-up boys. I also went in, I took my two children, and then we jumped in—I had some jewellery on me, things in my ears, on my wrists, and I had fourteen rupees on me. I took all that and threw it into the well, and then I jumped in, but . . . it's like when you put rotis into a tandoor, and if it is too full, the ones near the top, they don't cook, they have to be taken out. So the well filled up, and we could not drown . . . the children survived. Later, Nehru went to see the well, and the English then closed it up, the well that was full of bodies. The pathans took out those people who were at the top of the well—those

who died, died, and those who were alive, they pulled out. Then they went away—and what was left of our village was saved, except for that one girl who went away.

“I was frightened. Of course, I was . . . we were also frightened that we would be taken away by the Musalmaans. In our village, already, in the well that was inside the village, girls had jumped in. In the middle of the night they had jumped in. This happened where the morcha was. The hundred . . . eighty-four women who jumped in they were just outside, some two-hundred yards away from Lajjawanti’s house. In the morcha, the crowd had collected in Lajjawanti’s house. She was some seventy, seventy-five years old. A tall, strapping woman. She did a lot of seva of [service to] all the women, she herself jumped into the well. Many people were killed in the morcha, and the Musalmaans climbed on top to kill others, and then many came and tried to kill people with guns, one of them put a gun to my jeth’s chest and . . . and we began to jump in. The others had died earlier, and we were in the morcha, the well was some distance away from Lajjawanti’s house, in a garden. There were two wells, one inside and one outside, in the garden. My nanan [sister-in-law] and her daughter, they were both lying there . . . close by there was a ladle, I mixed afim in it, and gave it to them, and she put it in her mouth . . . she died, and I think the village dogs must have eaten her. We had no time to perform any last rites. An hour or so later, the trucks came. . . .

“She did path [oral recitation of prayers], and said don’t throw me away, let me have this afim, she took god’s name and then she died. We had afim because my jeth’s son used to eat it, and he had it with him and he got more and gave it to everyone. My jeth’s son, his daughter-in-law and his daughter, they died in Jhelum later, when we were going to the Dinia camp, on March 15 or so. The camp was close to the Jhelum. Four days we fought, and we remained strong, then around the 12th we got into the morcha, on the 13th our people were killed . . . then the trucks came . . . and took us to Rawat. . . .

“They brought us there [to the well]. From there . . . you know there was no place . . . nothing to eat, some people were eating close by but where could I give the children anything from . . . I had barely a few paise . . . my elder son had a duvanni (two annas) with him, we thought we could use that . . . my brother’s children were also hungry . . . but then they said the duvanni was khoti, damaged, unusable . . . [weeping] such difficulties . . . nothing to eat . . . we had to fill their stomachs . . . today they would have been ranis . . . so many of them, jethanis, children . . . I was the youngest . . . now I sit at home and my children are out working and I keep telling them these stories . . . they are stories after all . . . and you tell them and tell them until you lose consciousness . . .”

The abduction and rape of women, the physical mutilation of their bodies, the tattooing of their sexual organs with symbols of the other religion—these acts had been universally condemned. But no mention was made of family violence

by anyone—neither the families, nor the State, nor indeed by historians. . . . Its scale was not small. Virtually every village had similar stories. Gurmeet Singh, a survivor from village Thamali . . . in the same district, described their flight:

“On the night of the 12th of March we left at 4 a.m. . . . Our own family, all the people, we collected them in the gurudwara and got some men to guard them. We gave them orders to kill all the young girls, and as for the gurudwara, to pour oil on it and set it on fire.

“We decided this among ourselves. We felt totally helpless—so many people had collected, we were completely surrounded. If you looked around, all you could see was a sea of people . . . After all, you get frightened . . . people collected together to comfort each other. But then we found we were helpless . . . we had no weapons, whatever little we had they had taken. Then they took a decision in the gurudwara that all the young girls and women . . . two or three persons were assigned the task of finishing them off. Those in the gurudwara were asked to set it on fire with those inside . . . we killed all the young girls with our own hands; kerosene was poured over them inside the gurudwara and the place was set on fire . . . women and children, where could they go?”

Over the years, as I spoke to . . . more people, both men and women, I was to come across this response again. The tone adopted . . . was similar to that adopted by families when they spoke of the hundreds of women they had “martyred” in order to “save” the purity of the religion. . . .

Some negotiations had clearly taken place between the attackers and the victims in most of the villages. Kulwant Singh, another survivor, this time from Thamali, remembers a meeting at which an understanding was reached (between the two communities) that “we would be let off.” According to Kulwant Singh, the amount negotiated was between sixteen and thirty thousand rupees and the laying down of all weapons. Having done this, “at night they started fires and some of our sisters, daughters and others, in order to save their honour, their relatives, our veers [heroes], they martyred them and in this way . . . some of our women and children were killed. In the gurudwara there were piles of bodies.” There is no record of the numbers of women and children who were killed by the men of their own families, their own communities. Unlike in the case of abducted women, here families did not report the deaths of their women, for they themselves were responsible for them. But while abducted women then entered the realm of silence, women who were killed by families, or who took their own lives, entered the realm of martyrdom.

[From U. Butalia, *The Other Side of Silence*, 157–165.]